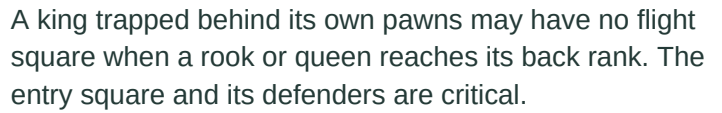


Back-rank mates

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Inspect the king's pawn shelter, then find how a heavy piece can enter the last rank or remove its defender.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on a1. Check for tactical protection.

Previous move: 17.Qxe5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

17...Qf2+ 18. Kh1 Qf1+ 19. Rxf1 Rxf1#

17...Qf2+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From f2 it attacks king on g1 and rook on e1. Recorded reply:
18.Kh1.

18...Qf1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From f1 it attacks king on h1 and rook on e1. Recorded reply:
19.Rxf1.

19...Rxf1# Mate: rook on f1 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on f1. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

A flight square, an interposition, or a countercheck may refute an apparent mate. Check all three before sacrificing material.